

Tether

Design system, component library, and screen-by-screen specification

Version 1.0 **Date** 17 Sept 2026 **Status** Ready for design production **Platforms** iOS 16+, Android 10+
Companion PRD · TRD · Backend Schema

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01 Design principles

1. Quiet, not loud

People open this app at vulnerable moments. No confetti explosions, no streak-shaming, no bright red badges. Celebration is a warm shift in colour, not a party.

2. One thing per screen

The daily prompt screen contains the prompt and nothing else. If a user has to look for the primary action, the screen has failed.

3. Never a dead end

No screen may exist where the user cannot proceed. Waiting, empty, or failed states always carry a next action. This principle directly targets the failure mode that damaged the predecessor product.

4. Both people, always visible

Where content is shared, both partners' presence is visible — avatars, names, states. Tether is not a single-player app wearing a couples costume.

02 Brand identity

Element	Specification
Name	Tether
Tagline	Two people. One practice.
Metaphor	A tether connects while allowing movement — the exact shape of a healthy relationship, and of an interfaith one.
Mark	Two distinct endpoints joined by a single continuous line. The line should have visible slack — it is not a rigid bar. Works at 24px. Monochrome-safe.
Personality	Warm, calm, intelligent, unhurried. Not clinical, not cute.
Avoid	Religious symbols of any kind. Heart icons. Stock photos of smiling couples. Anything that renders as clip-art spirituality.

03 Foundations

3.1 Colour

Core

-  Ink primary · #3C3489 brand, headings
-  Brand · #534AB7 primary actions
-  Brand tint · #EEEDFE surfaces
-  Text · #1B1A1F
-  Text muted · #6E6B7A
-  Surface · #F7F6FA
-  Border · #E3E1E9

Semantic

-  Thriving · #0F6E56
-  Drifting · #BA7517
-  Strained · #A32D2D
-  Accent · #D85A30 sparingly
-  Info · #185FA5

Wisdom track accents

-  Secular · #378ADD
-  Vedic · #BA7517
-  Quranic · #1D9E75
-  Biblical · #7F77DD

Colour rules

Track accents identify content, never decorate it. Never colour-code partners by gender. All semantic states must be distinguishable in greyscale — colour is never the only signal.

3.2 Typography

System font stack (SF Pro on iOS, Roboto on Android). No custom fonts at v1 — system fonts render better, ship instantly, and support Dynamic Type natively.

Style	Size	Weight	Usage
display	32 / 40	700	Welcome, celebration moments
title	24 / 32	700	Screen titles
headline	18 / 26	600	Section headers, the daily prompt itself
body	16 / 24	400	Default reading text
callout	15 / 22	400	Secondary content
caption	13 / 18	400	Metadata, timestamps
label	15 / 20	600	Buttons, form labels

3.3 Spacing, radius, elevation

Spacing 4pt base grid. 4 · 8 · 12 · 16 · 24 · 32 · 48 Screen margins: 20pt horizontal, 16pt vertical minimum.	Radius Small 8pt (chips, inputs) Medium 12pt (cards) Large 20pt (sheets) Full (avatars, mood dots)	Elevation No drop shadows. Depth via 1px borders and surface tint only. Flat is calmer and renders consistently.
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04 Component library

Atoms

Component	Variants	Specification
Button	primary, secondary, tertiary, destructive	Height 52pt minimum touch target. Radius 12pt. Primary uses brand fill. One primary per screen.
MoodDot	5 states, unselected	36pt circles in a row. Colour ramps from Strained red to Thriving green. Must be distinguishable in greyscale — use size and label alongside colour.
Avatar	sm 32, md 44, lg 72	Circular. Initials or uploaded image. Never gender-coded by default.
PairBadge	solo, pending, paired	Shows coupling status anywhere couple context matters.
Chip	track, filter, state	Height 32pt, radius 8pt. Track chips carry their accent colour as a 3pt leading bar.
StreakRing	active, frozen, broken	Progress ring with count. Frozen state uses a dashed ring, never red.
PulseIndicator	thriving, drifting, strained, unknown	Small pill with icon plus text label. Never colour-only.
PrivateToggle	shared, private	Explicit visibility control on any composable surface. Default state configurable per surface.

Molecules

- **PromptCard** — the day's question, date, and a track chip. The hero of the home screen.
- **ReplyRow** — avatar, one-line reply, timestamp. Locked state shows a covered placeholder with "Reveals when you both answer."
- **PartnerRow** — avatar, name, last-active, nudge action. Used in waiting room and settings.
- **InviteMethod** — link, QR, code. All three always visible together, never behind a tab.
- **WisdomTrackCard** — icon, name, one-line description, selected state. Four cards, equal visual weight — no implied ranking.
- **JournalEntry** — mood dot, text, visibility indicator, date.
- **CoachBubble** — AI message with streaming indicator and a persistent "not therapy" affordance.
- **ResourceCard** — crisis resources. Calm, high contrast, no branding flourish.
- **PaywallFeature** — icon, title, one-line benefit. Privacy promise appears as a feature row.

Organisms

- **DailyLoop** — PromptCard + MoodDot row + input + lock state + streak. The entire habit in one component.
- **InviteSheet** — three methods, share sheet integration, copy-to-clipboard.

- **WaitingRoom** — status, elapsed time, copyable message, refresh, solo escape hatch.
- **CoachThread** — message list, voice button, streaming, disclaimer footer.
- **PulsePanel** — current state, trend, tap-through explanation.

05 Motion specification

Interaction	Duration	Easing / notes
Screen transition	250ms	Standard ease-out. Cross-dissolve for tab changes.
Reply unlock reveal	400ms	The one moment earned theatre. Gentle scale and fade, never confetti.
Mood dot select	150ms	Immediate tactile feedback.
AI token streaming	—	Typewriter, 18ms/token. Never a blocking spinner.
Pairing success	600ms	Warm brand-tint wash and both avatars converging. Celebration without noise.
Loading	—	Skeleton screens, never spinners, for anything over 400ms.

Reduced motion — honour the OS setting. Replace all animation with instant state change or opacity-only fades. No exceptions.

06 Accessibility

- **WCAG 2.1 AA minimum.** Contrast 4.5:1 for body text, 3:1 for large text and UI components.
- **Dynamic Type** — all text scales to 200% without clipping or overlap. Test every screen at maximum.
- **VoiceOver / TalkBack** — every interactive element labelled. Mood dots announce state and value ("3 of 5").
- **Touch targets** — 44×44pt minimum. Mood dots are 36pt visually but must have a 44pt hit area.
- **Colour independence** — no state communicated by colour alone. Pulse, mood, and streak all carry text or shape.
- **Reduced motion** and **increased contrast** both honoured.

07 Screen inventory

#	Screen	Priority	Purpose
1	Splash	P0	Brand moment. Under 1.5s, skippable.
2	Welcome	P0	Name, promise, get started.
3	Wisdom track selection	P0	Four equal options. "Yours alone — change anytime."
4	Love Languages	P0	20 questions, under 2 min, immediate result.
5	Home / daily loop	P0	The core habit. One prompt, mood, reply.
6	Invite partner	P0	Link + QR + code, all visible.
7	Waiting room	P0	Status, copyable message, solo escape.
8	Pairing success	P0	Celebration. Start of shared streak.
9	Solo mode home	P0	Full-value solo experience. Invite affordance present but not nagging.
10	Journal	P0	Chronological entries, search, export.
11	Relationship Pulse	P0	State, trend, explanation.
12	AI coach	P0	Text and voice, streaming, disclaimer.
13	Paywall	P0	Trial, pricing, "one sub covers both."
14	Settings	P0	Account, track, notifications, privacy, delete.
15	Safety resource	P0	Crisis support. Partner never sees this.
16	Weekly recap	P1	Sunday summary.
17	Track switch	P1	Change wisdom track with history preserved.
18	Onboarding progress	P1	Seven-day ritual progress.

08 Screen specifications

Screen 3 — Wisdom track selection P0

Aspect	Specification
Purpose	User selects the framework their content will speak from.
Header	"What wisdom speaks to you?" Subhead: "This is yours alone. Your partner chooses their own."
Content	Four cards, equal size and visual weight: Secular & Psychology · Vedic & Dharmic · Quranic · Biblical. Each with icon, name, and one-line description. At v0.1 ship Secular and Biblical live; others show "Coming soon" rather than being hidden — the promise matters.
Interaction	Tap to select, single choice. Continue button disabled until chosen.
States	Selected (brand border, 2pt, accent leading bar). Unselected (1pt neutral border). Coming soon (reduced opacity, badge).
Critical copy	"Yours alone" must appear. It is the entire differentiator and must be legible, not buried.

Screen 5 — Home / daily loop P0

Aspect	Specification
Purpose	The whole habit. Completable in under 60 seconds.
Layout (top→bottom)	Date and streak ring · PromptCard with today's question · MoodDot row (5 dots) · one-line input with voice button · partner status row showing locked or revealed state.
Locked state	Partner's reply area shows a covered placeholder: "Reveals when you both answer." Never show a partial or blurred reply — that reads as a tease and erodes trust.
Revealed state	Both replies visible, side by side or stacked with avatars. Optional reaction. No comment thread in v1.
Solo variant	No lock. Reply saves immediately. A quiet, non-nagging invite affordance below.
Missed day	Offer freeze rather than showing a broken streak. Copy: "Keep your streak? You have 2 freezes left."
Paywall hook	Free tier sees a limited number of prompts per week. Never block today's prompt if the user has already started it.

Screen 6 & 7 — Invite and waiting room P0

This is the most important flow in the product

The predecessor product failed here. Every screen must offer a way forward. No state in this flow may be terminal.

Aspect	Specification
Invite screen	All three methods visible simultaneously: a large share button, a QR code, and a 6-digit code. No tabs, no hiding.
Waiting room	Shows: elapsed time since invite, a pre-written copyable message ("Hey — I found something I'd like us to try together"), a manual refresh, and nudge controls.
Never	An unexplained spinner. A blank state. A screen with no action available.
24h	"Invite sent yesterday. Send a reminder?" with one-tap WhatsApp / iMessage / SMS.
72h	Proactive offer, visually prominent: "Start on your own. Everything you write syncs the moment they join." One tap into Solo Mode.
Success	Both avatars converge, brand-tint wash, both partners pushed. Marks shared streak start.

Screen 12 — AI coach P0

Aspect	Specification
Layout	Message thread, coach avatar top-left, input bar with text and voice. Persistent footer: "Tether is not therapy."
Streaming	Typewriter from 18ms per token. Typing indicator before first token. Never a blocking spinner.
Voice	Press-and-hold or tap mic. Waveform while recording. Spoken playback option on responses.
Memory	When the coach references past context, show a subtle "Remembering" indicator. Transparency builds trust and differentiates from a stateless chatbot.
Refusal	Warm and brief, never a lecture. Offer the next best step (a human professional, a prompt, or a pause).
Privacy	Header affordance opens encryption explanation. "Your conversations are encrypted. We cannot read them."

Screen 13 — Paywall P0

- **Headline** — a benefit, not a feature list.
- **Critical line, prominent** — **"One subscription. Both partners. Always."**
- **Feature rows** — daily prompts, full content library, AI coach, unlimited journal. **Include privacy as a feature row** ("End-to-end encrypted").
- **Options** — annual (\$79.99) pre-selected with savings shown, monthly (\$12.99) secondary.
- **Trial** — "14 days free, then \$79.99/year. Cancel anytime."
- **Placement** — after the first value moment, never on launch.
- **Restore** — visible text link. Required.

09 States

State	Requirements
Empty	Must teach, not just fill space. Journal empty state shows a sample entry with "Your entries will look like this." Always carries a primary action.
Loading	Skeleton screens above 400ms. Spinners only for sub-400ms operations.
Error	Plain language, what happened, what to do. Never an error code alone. Always a retry.
Offline	Quiet persistent banner: "Offline — your entries are saved." Never a blocking modal. Full functionality retained.
Paused	If the user has paused notifications, show a gentle "Resume" affordance, not a warning.
Crisis	Calm, high contrast, unbranded. Resource card replaces normal content. Partner sees nothing.

10 Voice and tone

We are Warm · plain · calm · respectful · brief	We are not Cheerful · clinical · preachy · cutesy · urgent	We never Guilt · diagnose · prescribe · assume · shame
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Write this	Not this
"Start on your own. Everything syncs when they join."	"Come back when your partner joins!"
"Keep your streak? You have 2 freezes left."	"You broke your 12-day streak!"
"You've been drifting for two weeks."	"Your relationship is in trouble."
"This is yours alone. Your partner chooses their own."	"Select your faith."
"Tether isn't therapy. Here's what might help."	"I'm not able to help with that."

Sensitive content rules — no exclamation marks anywhere near conflict, crisis, or Pulse. Sentence case everywhere, never title case for buttons. No emoji in system copy.

11 Localisation readiness

- **Build RTL-ready now**, even though v0.1 is English-only. Retrofitting directionality is expensive; Urdu and Arabic are on the roadmap.
- **Text expansion** — allow 35% growth. German and Hindi both run longer than English.
- **No text in images**. Ever. All strings externalised from day one.

- **Date, number, and name formatting** — locale-aware via Intl APIs.
- **Launch sequence** — English (v0.1) → Spanish (v1.0) → Hindi (v1.5) → Tamil, Telugu, Urdu (v2.0). A language ships only when a native speaker owns its content.

Tether · UI/UX Specification v1.0 · Companion documents: PRD, TRD, Backend Schema, Strategy Plan.